Automation Mindset

MESA SCHOOL OF BUSINESS



Sumanyu Madaan

Sold agentic AI systems generating $2M revenue, to BFSI enterprises like EY and IIFL

Ex GTM Lead at Alltius (Agentic AI)

Chief of Staff at OSlash (Productivity SaaS)

Sr Analyst at Bain and Co (Made Slides)

Headed Placecom at SRCC, making automations pre-GPT era.

The First Week of an AI Generalist

Story of Soham

AI Generalist

FinFlow AI, a B2B SaaS company

Mission: “Make the company faster.”



Monday, 9:30 AM

Soham walks into a growing B2B SaaS company and sits with the Founder!

Everyone has work. Everyone has tools. Everyone has pain.

The company

Sales	Customer Success	Marketing
Finance	HR	Product
Founder		



The founder’s brief

“Find where AI and automation can create leverage.”

AI

CRM

Slack

Sheets

n8n



By lunch, Soham has 14 requests

Sales
Research every prospect

CS
Summarize calls + flag risks

Marketing
Turn webinars into posts

Finance
Invoice follow-ups

HR
AI resume screening

Founder
One dashboard for everything



Classic founder move. One dashboard to rule them all.

Soham starts building

He opens the tools, he understands the work, he builds automations!

n8n | Zapier | GPT | CRM | Notion | Slack | Sheets



By next Friday, 6 automations are live

…while the founder was in the States.

Prospect Research Bot

Enriches leads before demos

Sales Follow-Up Writer

Drafts emails after calls

Customer Risk Alerts

Flags churn signals in Slack

Invoice Reminder Workflow

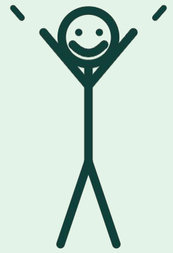
Sends payment nudges

Resume Screening Assistant

Scores candidates

Founder Dashboard

Shows “everything”



Impressive(?)!

Monday catchup

The automations work. The company pushes back.

Prospect Research
Too generic

Follow-Up Writer
Misses context

Risk Alerts
Too noisy

Invoice Reminders
Commercially risky

Resume Screening
Rejects good candidates

Dashboard
No decision attached



Surgery was successful, patient died!

Automations worked. The company didn’t.

Automation

Executed successfully ✓

Operations

No real leverage ?



The failure was not technical. The failure was conceptual.

Soham asked the wrong question

“What can I automate?”

report? reminder? email?

approval? dashboard? follow-up?

hiring? escalation?

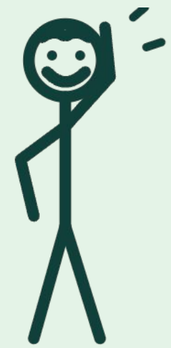


A trap: every repeated task starts looking like an opportunity.

The better question

“Should this be automated, and if yes, how?”

WORKFLOW			
	Delete	Simplify	Delegate
	Automate	AI assist	Keep human



Automation is not a tool skill.
It is a judgment skill.

So what is this course really about?

This course is about learning how to look at work like a systems designer.

Before you automate the work, understand the work.

Not automation tools.

Not prompt tricks.

Not “10 workflows to copy.”

The mindset shift

Move from tool-first building to judgment-first automation design.

Tool-first

“What can I build?”

Fast demos. Fragile impact.



Judgment-first

“What deserves leverage?”

Clear problem. Better system.

Objective of the day

By the end, you should be able to…

01

Identify workflows worth automating

02

Break messy work into system components

03

Decide where AI actually adds value

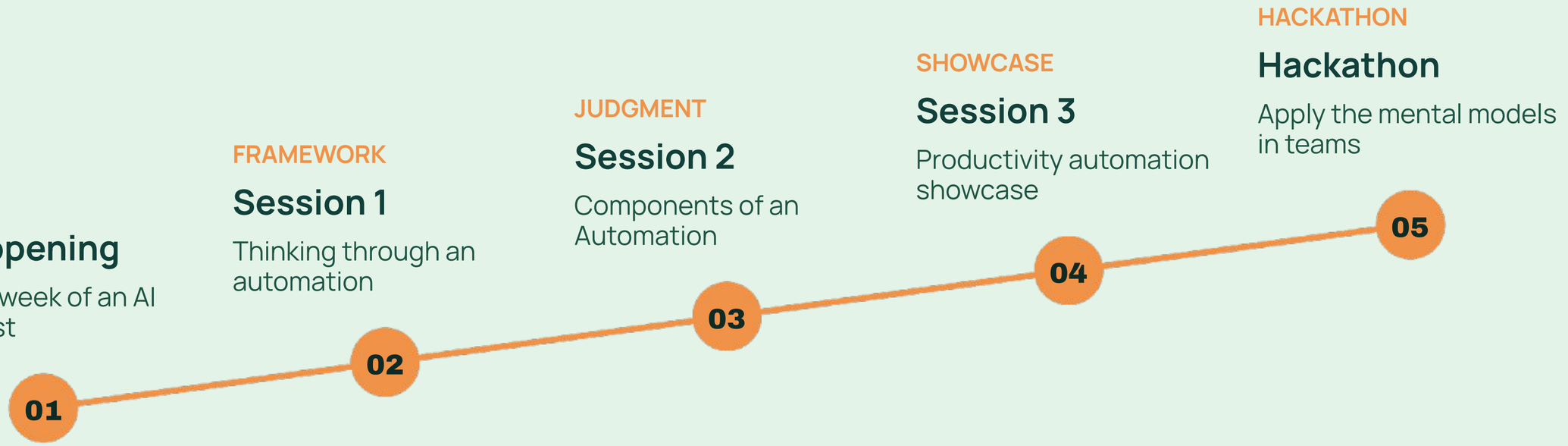
04

Get productivity tips

05

Present an automation idea clearly

Today’s flow


STORY
Case opening
The first week of an AI Generalist
01
FRAMEWORK
Session 1
Thinking through an automation
02
JUDGMENT
Session 2
Components of an Automation
03
SHOWCASE
Session 3
Productivity automation showcase
04
HACKATHON
Hackathon
Apply the mental models in teams
05

A few rules

Ask questions, and lets discuss examples!

The only rule

If the answer starts with a tool name, we probably asked the wrong question.

01

Thinking through an automation

The first automation skill is not building. It is judgment.

What is an automation?

Ask the room

A system that moves work forward without a human manually pushing every step.

Step 01

Trigger

Something happens.

→

Step 02

Logic

The system decides.

→

Step 03

Action

Work moves forward.

If there is no output, there is no value.

Start with a why

Why should “this” be automated?

The first automation skill is not building. It is judgment.

“WHY?”

Before opening a tool, let’s try asking questions.

Pain

What hurts today?

User

Who feels it?

Outcome

What changes if we solve it?

Never automate a vague problem. Vague problems create vague systems.

Questions?

“This?: Quarterly MIS”

Pain

Investor relations

User

Investor

Outcome

Paisaa hi Paisa Hoga!

Simple?

“This?: Quarterly MIS”

Ask more questions

What is the pain?

Delay in reporting numbers

Who consumes?

Investor

Who owns it?

Finance

Impact?

Investor relations?*

Frequency?

Once in 3 months

Urgency?

NAH

Outcomes?

NAH

Simpler!

Let’s take one more example?!

Ask more questions

What is the pain?	Who consumes?	Who owns it?	Impact?
Frequency?	Urgency?	Outcomes?	**Simpler!**

Keep, fix, kill, or redesign?

Remember Soham?

Prospect research — Fix	Sales follow-up writer — Redesign	Customer risk alerts — Fix
Invoice capture — Redesign	Resume screening — Redesign	Founder dashboard — Kill / Redesign
Visiting card scanner — Redesign	Meeting recorder — Redesign	MIS dashboard — Kill / Redesign

The point is not the answer. The point is the reasoning.

Automation judgment checklist

01 Problem real?	**02** Workflow repeated?	**03** Input available?	**04** Output valuable?	**05** Impact measurable?
06 Failure risk acceptable?	**07** Judgment protected?	**08** ROI worth it?	**09** Data reliable?	**10** Owner clear?

This is the checklist students use before they touch a tool.

02

Components of a great automation!

If you cannot map the workflow, you cannot automate it.

Soham closes n8n and opens a blank page.

Components breakdown

1	2	3	4	5	6
Trigger	Input	Context	Processing	AI	Output

Tools	Chosen last, once the six above are settled.

Takeaway: automation design is not tool selection. It is workflow clarity before the first click.

Example

Case: A high-intent webinar lead comes in. What actually needs to happen next?

1 · Trigger	2 · Input	3 · Context	4 · Processing	5 · AI	6 · Output
New webinar lead submitted	Name · email company · role	Form + CRM attendance data	Deduplicate, junk removal	Draft follow-up extract intent	Email + CRM Slack alert

Tools Gmail, CRM, Google Sheets

What the system does

Moves data across tools Applies rules consistently Notifies the right owner

Where AI adds value

Personalizes the message Summarizes intent Suggests next best action

What stays human

Approves high-value outreach Handles exceptions Owns judgment + accountability

Takeaway: automation design is not tool selection. It is workflow clarity before the first click.

Human in the loop ladder

L1
Suggest
AI research + process

L2
Prepare
AI drafts

L3
Approve
Human confirms

L4
Execute
System acts

L5
Learn
Feedback improves

Understand the difference between good and good enough.

Human · AI · System split

System

Repetition Rules Routing Scheduling

AI

Language Classification Drafting Pattern detection

Human

Judgment Emotion Accountability Final high-risk action

Soham's six automations never drew this line. That was the bug.

Can AI replace the “Human” in the loop?

Maker - Checker!

Maker
Does the work

Checker
Owns the risk



The maker and checker concept!

03

Automations and productivity!

Do not copy the tools. Learn to see the pattern.



Soham rebuilds two of the six. This time he starts with the why.

The Co-Working Agents!

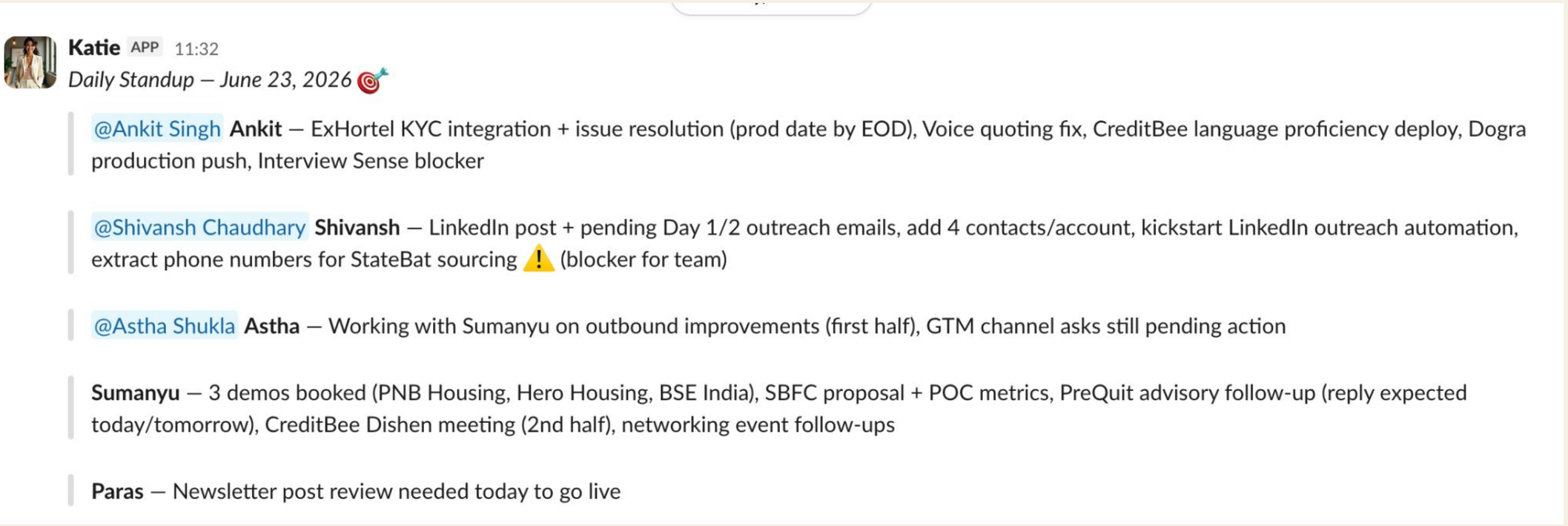
Co Working Agents acts as AI Employees which ends up knowing more about the company than any single employee — are faster, more accurate and dont need breaks!



Katie

Chief of Staff to Sumanyu

Daily Standup Brief!



Katie APP 11:32

Daily Standup — June 23, 2026 🎯

> @Ankit Singh **Ankit** — ExHortel KYC integration + issue resolution (prod date by EOD), Voice quoting fix, CreditBee language proficiency deploy, Dogra production push, Interview Sense blocker

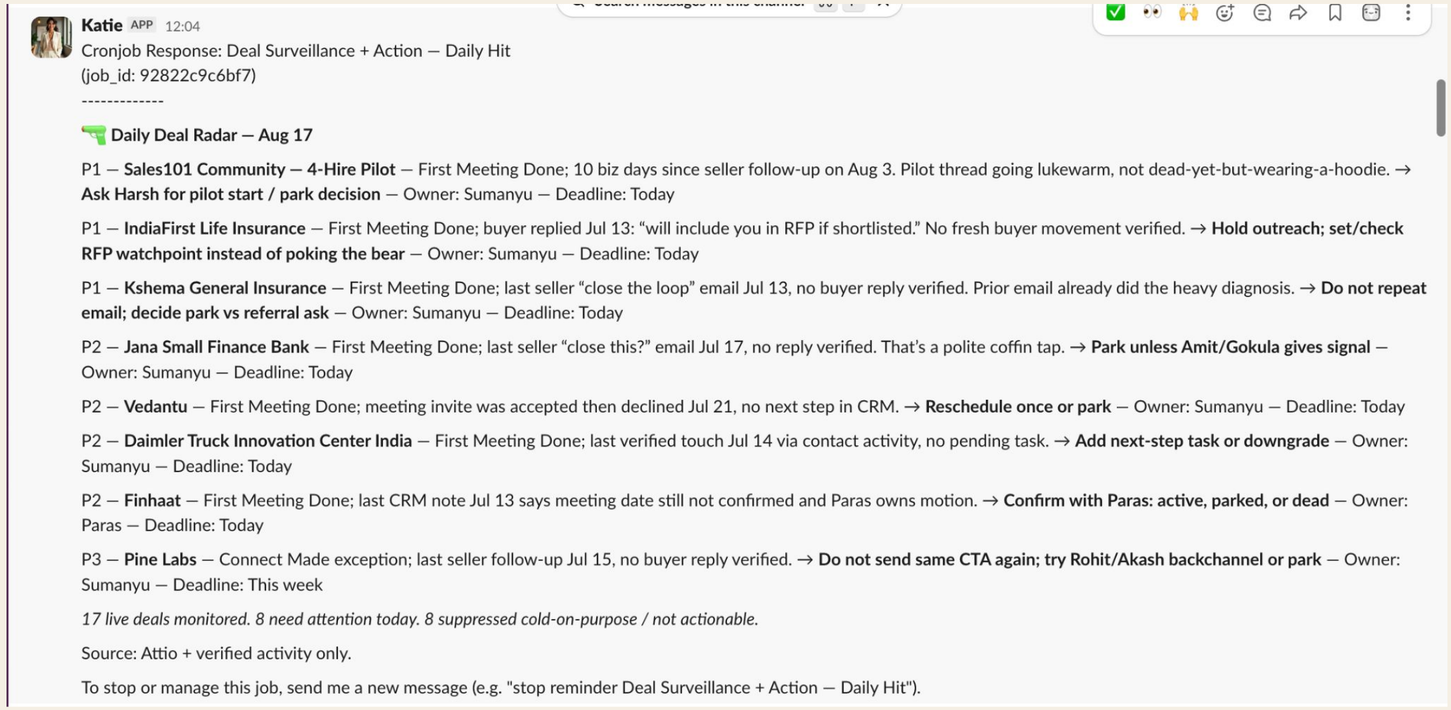
> @Shivansh Chaudhary **Shivansh** — LinkedIn post + pending Day 1/2 outreach emails, add 4 contacts/account, kickstart LinkedIn outreach automation, extract phone numbers for StateBat sourcing ⚠️ (blocker for team)

> @Astha Shukla **Astha** — Working with Sumanyu on outbound improvements (first half), GTM channel asks still pending action

> **Sumanyu** — 3 demos booked (PNB Housing, Hero Housing, BSE India), SBFC proposal + POC metrics, PreQuit advisory follow-up (reply expected today/tomorrow), CreditBee Dishen meeting (2nd half), networking event follow-ups

> **Paras** — Newsletter post review needed today to go live

Deal Radar



Katie APP 12:04
Cronjob Response: Deal Surveillance + Action — Daily Hit
(job_id: 92822c9c6bf7)

Daily Deal Radar — Aug 17

P1 — **Sales101 Community — 4-Hire Pilot** — First Meeting Done; 10 biz days since seller follow-up on Aug 3. Pilot thread going lukewarm, not dead-yet-but-wearing-a-hoodie. → **Ask Harsh for pilot start / park decision** — Owner: Sumanyu — Deadline: Today

P1 — **IndiaFirst Life Insurance** — First Meeting Done; buyer replied Jul 13: "will include you in RFP if shortlisted." No fresh buyer movement verified. → **Hold outreach; set/check RFP watchpoint instead of poking the bear** — Owner: Sumanyu — Deadline: Today

P1 — **Kshema General Insurance** — First Meeting Done; last seller "close the loop" email Jul 13, no buyer reply verified. Prior email already did the heavy diagnosis. → **Do not repeat email; decide park vs referral ask** — Owner: Sumanyu — Deadline: Today

P2 — **Jana Small Finance Bank** — First Meeting Done; last seller "close this?" email Jul 17, no reply verified. That's a polite coffin tap. → **Park unless Amit/Gokula gives signal** — Owner: Sumanyu — Deadline: Today

P2 — **Vedantu** — First Meeting Done; meeting invite was accepted then declined Jul 21, no next step in CRM. → **Reschedule once or park** — Owner: Sumanyu — Deadline: Today

P2 — **Daimler Truck Innovation Center India** — First Meeting Done; last verified touch Jul 14 via contact activity, no pending task. → **Add next-step task or downgrade** — Owner: Sumanyu — Deadline: Today

P2 — **Finhaat** — First Meeting Done; last CRM note Jul 13 says meeting date still not confirmed and Paras owns motion. → **Confirm with Paras: active, parked, or dead** — Owner: Paras — Deadline: Today

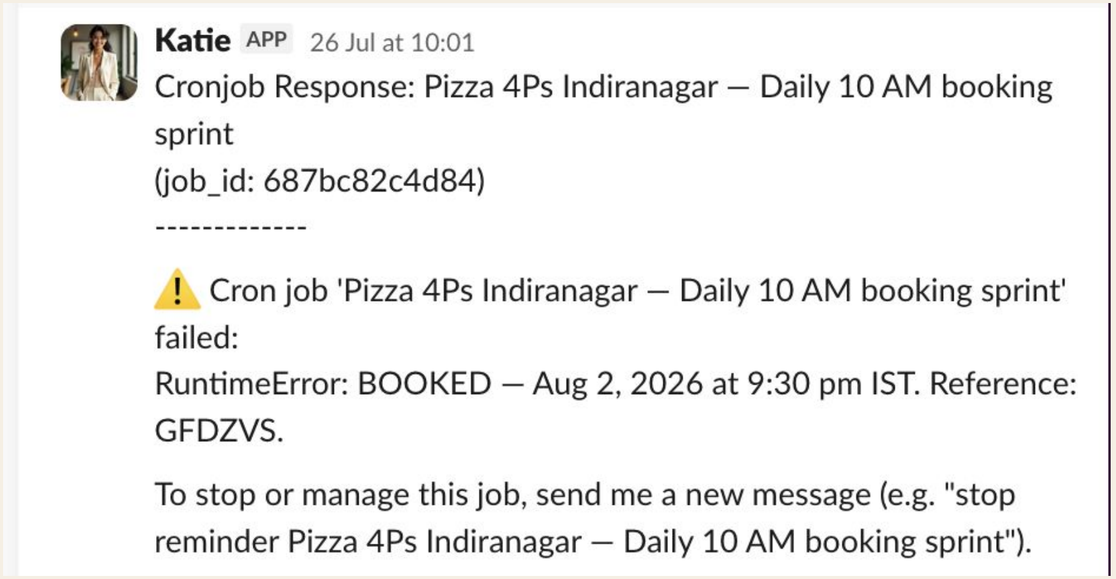
P3 — **Pine Labs** — Connect Made exception; last seller follow-up Jul 15, no buyer reply verified. → **Do not send same CTA again; try Rohit/Akash backchannel or park** — Owner: Sumanyu — Deadline: This week

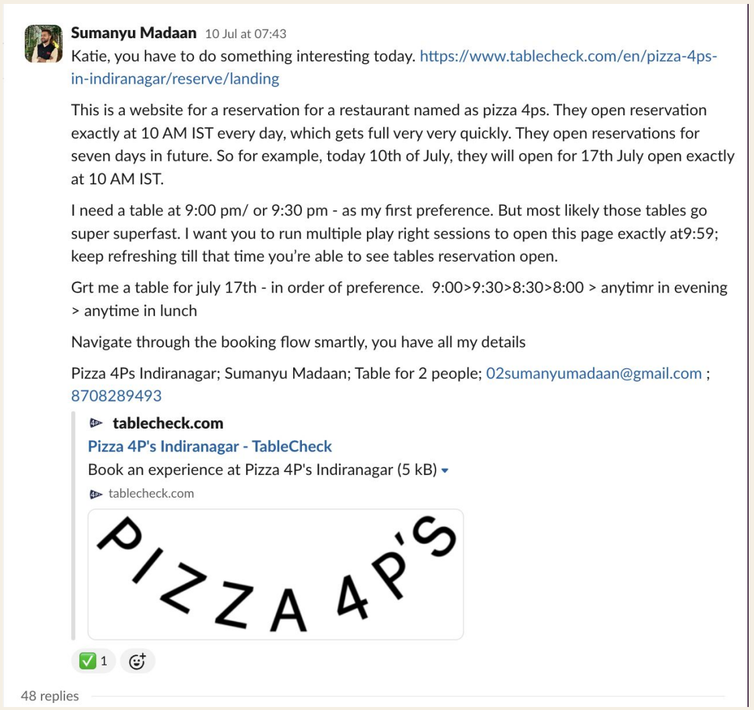
17 live deals monitored. 8 need attention today. 8 suppressed cold-on-purpose / not actionable.

Source: Attio + verified activity only.

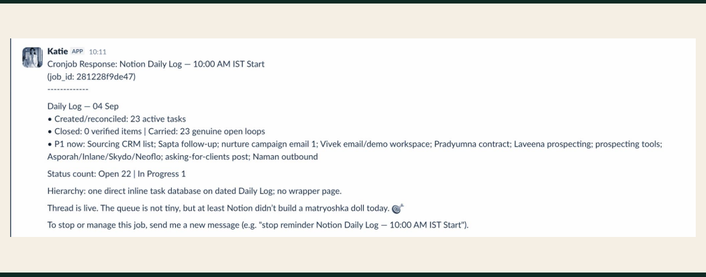
To stop or manage this job, send me a new message (e.g. "stop reminder Deal Surveillance + Action — Daily Hit").

Table Bookings!

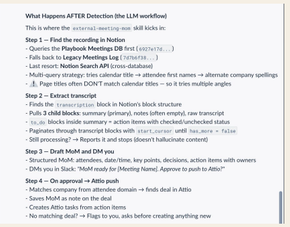


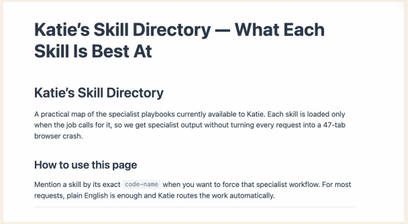


119 Skills till date and counting:

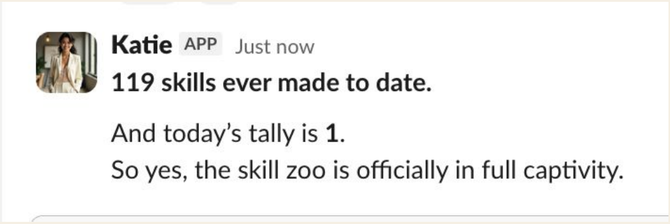








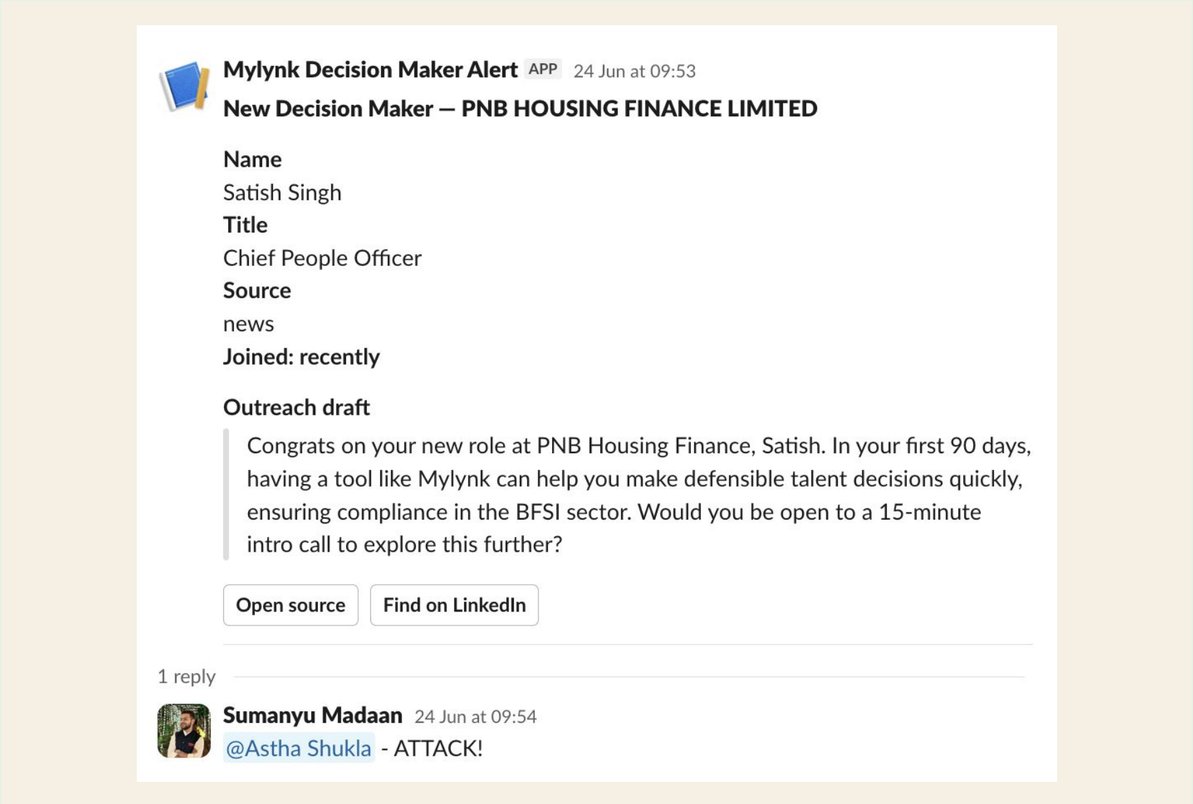




GTM Signals

New decision maker appointed

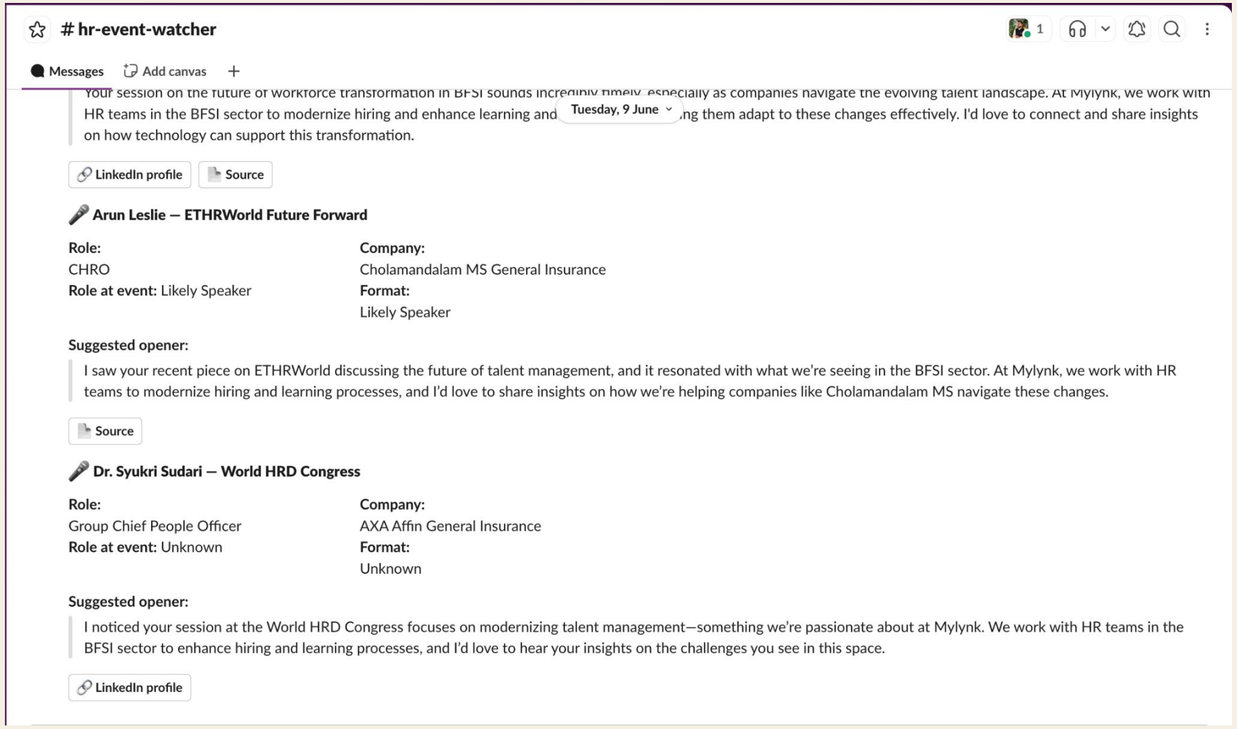
Generally leadership changes bring opportunity for new vendors!



GTM Signals

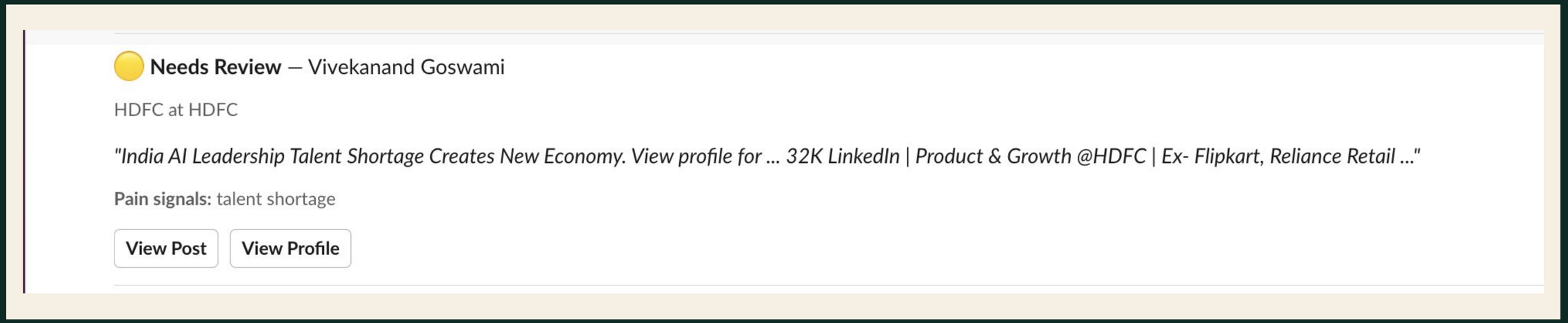
Events and Seminars

We met you there but we couldn't speak!



GTM Signals

Pain Directly Posted!



LinkedIn Post Maker

Let’s Discuss?

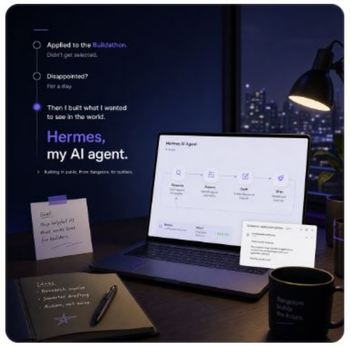
Done — made 2 LinkedIn-ready image options.

Option 1: “Built from home”
More personal + humble. Best if the post opens with *“I applied, didn’t make it, but still wanted to learn.”*

Option 2: “41 posts → patterns”
More analytical. Best if the post is framed around Sophie analyzing the hackathon posts and pulling out the bigger lesson.

My pick: **Option 1** if we want warmth. **Option 2** if we want the “AI agent did the homework” angle.

2 files | Download all





Technologies worth knowing

01
Playwright
Browser automation

02
Apify
Scraping and extraction

03
Hermes
Personal AI workflows

04
Obsidian
Knowledge systems

05
Paperclip
Context capture

06
Local screen control

07
WhatsApp workflows

08
Cron jobs
Scheduled automations

09
10 Min Email

10
10 Min Email

Productivity tools and tricks I use

01
Raycast

02
minimi

03
Wispr Flo

04
Arc Browser

05
Notion